

'I Call the Shots': Trump-Netanyahu Rift Exposes Diverging War Aims

From: Al Jazeera Mined: 2026-06-09 5 min read

The once-**unshakable** bond between President Donald Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu is showing its deepest **fracture** yet, as their interests collide over the war with Iran. Last week, Trump reportedly called Netanyahu 'f***ing crazy' during a phone call, accusing him of **undermining** U.S. diplomacy and warning that Israel's military escalation risked derailing peace talks. The tension erupted after Iran launched missiles at northern Israel on Sunday, **retaliating** for an Israeli strike in Beirut despite U.S. assurances days earlier that such an attack would not occur. 'He will have no choice,' Trump told the Financial Times. 'I call the shots. I call all the shots. He doesn't call the shots.' The confrontation has since paused, but analysts say the rift reflects fundamentally incompatible political needs. In the U.S., the war is deeply unpopular and has driven up oil prices after Iran effectively closed the Strait of Hormuz, a **chokepoint** for one-fifth of global oil and LNG supplies. With midterm elections approaching, Trump urgently needs a peace deal. Netanyahu, by contrast, could benefit domestically from continued conflict. 'It's a **transactional** relationship,' said Yossi Mekelberg of Chatham House. 'When it doesn't work for you, it's over.' The war itself has fallen short of Israeli hopes for a quick victory and regime change in Iran. Instead, the conflict has rattled energy markets and exposed what Mekelberg called Washington's 'inability to think strategically.' Despite the friction, the U.S. remains Israel's most vital diplomatic shield and military supplier, especially as European allies distance themselves. But the public spat signals that Trump's patience is wearing thin. As one observer noted, the two leaders have 'unravelling the Middle East,' and now their clashing agendas threaten to unravel their alliance.

Word Treasure

unshakable -- Impossible to weaken or destroy.

fracture -- A break or crack, often in a relationship.

undermining -- Gradually weakening or harming something, such as a plan or authority.

retaliating -- Fighting back in response to an attack.

chokepoint -- A narrow route that, if blocked, can stop the flow of important goods.

transactional -- Based on exchanging benefits, like a business deal, rather than on trust or values.

Background you need

Donald Trump (U.S. president since 2025) and Benjamin Netanyahu (Israel's longest-serving prime minister) have appeared close in the past, especially after Trump moved the U.S. embassy to Jerusalem and brokered the Abraham Accords, which normalized relations between Israel and several Arab countries.

However, recent events have strained their alliance. An Israeli strike in Beirut triggered an Iranian missile response, despite U.S. assurances that such an escalation would be avoided. This exposed conflicting strategies and angered Trump, who sees a peace deal as vital for upcoming midterm elections.

The Strait of Hormuz (a narrow waterway between Iran and Oman) is crucial because about one-fifth of the world's oil and liquefied natural gas passes through it. Iran effectively closed the strait during the fighting, driving up energy prices and hurting the U.S. economy.

Chatham House (a respected London-based think tank) analyst Yossi Mekelberg called the relationship 'transactional' -- meaning both leaders support each other only when it benefits their own political survival. Now that their interests clash, the partnership is unravelling.

The conflict has also failed to deliver Israel the quick victory it hoped for. Instead, it has rattled global markets and exposed what some experts see as a lack of long-term strategic thinking in Washington. The public spat signals that Trump's patience is running thin, though the U.S. remains Israel's most powerful backer.

Break it down

LEAD: The once-solid Trump-Netanyahu bond shows its deepest crack

+ TRIGGER: Trump's reported insult -- 'f***ing crazy'

ESCALATION DETAIL: Iran missiles hit Israel in retaliation for Beirut strike

+ CONTEXT: U.S. had assured such an attack would not happen

TRUMP'S ASSERTION OF POWER: 'I call the shots'

UNDERLYING POLITICAL NEEDS

+ TRUMP: War unpopular, oil prices up, midterms approaching -> needs peace

+ NETANYAHU: Could benefit domestically from continued conflict

ANALYST VIEW: Relationship is transactional

+ YOSSI MEKELBERG, Chatham House: 'When it doesn't work for you, it's over'

WIDER FALLOUT

+ Israeli war goals not achieved, quick victory absent

+ Energy markets rattled, Strait of Hormuz disruption

+ Washington's 'inability to think strategically' exposed

DESPITE CRACK, THE ALLIANCE HOLDS: U.S. remains Israel's vital shield & supplier

OPEN QUESTION: Will clashing agendas unravel the alliance permanently, or is this just a temporary outburst?

Why it matters

When powerful allies like the U.S. and Israel clash, it can change energy prices you'll feel at the pump, reshape Middle East borders, and test whether decades-old alliances survive when leaders' personal interests diverge -- all of which could affect your world's stability.

Test what you remember

1. What did President Trump reportedly call Prime Minister Netanyahu during a phone call?
 - (A) A brilliant strategist
 - (B) 'F***ing crazy'
 - (C) A loyal ally
 - (D) Too cautious
2. Why did Iran launch missiles at northern Israel?
 - (A) To test new weapons
 - (B) In retaliation for an Israeli strike in Beirut
 - (C) Because of a diplomatic insult
 - (D) To close the Strait of Hormuz
3. According to the article, what is driving President Trump's need for a peace deal?
 - (A) Pressure from European allies
 - (B) The war is unpopular in the U.S. and oil prices have risen
 - (C) He wants to win a Nobel Peace Prize
 - (D) Netanyahu asked him to
4. What is the Strait of Hormuz and why does it matter in this conflict?
 - (A) A desert region where most of Israel's water comes from
 - (B) A chokepoint for one-fifth of global oil and LNG supplies
 - (C) A military base jointly controlled by the U.S. and Iran
 - (D) The sea route used by United Nations peacekeepers
5. How did Yossi Mekelberg of Chatham House describe the Trump-Netanyahu relationship?
 - (A) A long-term friendship built on trust
 - (B) An ideological partnership
 - (C) A transactional relationship
 - (D) A formal military alliance only
6. Despite the public rift, what role does the U.S. still play for Israel?
 - (A) It provides most of Israel's grain
 - (B) It serves as Israel's most vital diplomatic shield and military supplier
 - (C) It controls Israel's borders
 - (D) It decides Israel's domestic policies

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Positive / supportive of Trump's pressure: By demanding a halt to escalation, Trump could prevent a wider war that would harm civilians, cool oil markets, and allow diplomatic efforts to address the root causes of the Iran-Israel standoff. A strong alliance can sometimes mean saying no to a partner for the greater good.

2. Negative / critical of the rift: Publicly insulting an ally undermines trust and could embolden Iran. Israel relies on U.S. diplomatic cover and military supplies, and a fractured relationship might lead to a more dangerous, isolated Israel, increasing the chance of a prolonged conflict.

3. Neutral / analytical: The spat reveals the transactional nature of many international alliances. Both leaders use the relationship for domestic political survival, not shared values. This incident is a textbook example of how personal chemistry can override strategic interests, then break down when conditions change.

4. Forward-looking: If Trump pressures Israel into a ceasefire and a credible deal with Iran, it could reshape Middle Eastern diplomacy for years. If the rift deepens, we might see Israel seek new security partners or accelerate controversial military actions, with unpredictable consequences for global stability.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):